

CAD FORUM**RESEARCHING NON-PRESIDENTIAL DEBATES:****A MOMENT IN TIME****Allan Loudon, Editor**

The occurrence of presidential to non-presidential debates is overwhelmingly in favor of state and local debates. Virtually every U.S. senate contest and governor's race, in addition to many congressional elections, will feature political debates. These non-presidential debates substantially outnumber the every-fourth-year presidential debates. Frankly, no one knows the ratio, as tracking of non-presidential debates has remained localized. Efforts are underway to address bringing state debates to a larger audience,¹ yet the tracking process is daunting.

The disparity between published research examining non-presidential debates with Presidential contests is equally unbalanced, with the presidential encounters capturing nearly all of the attention. Published presidential studies outnumber state debate articles by a ratio of seventy-five to one.²

Undoubtedly, presidential debates have more reach and influence on the political culture, but, increasingly, state-level debates command national attention. C-SPAN, network outlets like *Meet the Press* and the Internet,³ combined with the nationalization of many races, contribute to their importance. These trends, combined with the ability to obtain examples for academic examination, portend expanding research in non-presidential debates.

¹ Debatescoop.com is a new Web meeting place, launched in September 2006, which brings together expert commentary by academic political debate experts, event links to video and audio of debates, and media and campaign access to debate information from analysis to planning.

² This number is based on a comprehensive bibliography maintained by the author (Louden, 2006) at <http://www.wfu.edu/~louden/Political%20Communication/Bibs/DEBATES.html>

³ For example many high-profile state contests are being conducted on shows like Tim Russert's *Meet the Press*. Also bloggers and political sites, combined with streaming video via state news

There has never been a shortage of observation that non- presidential debates are widespread and integral (Ornstein, 1988) to shaping political culture, but there has been a shortage of academic inquiry.

Non-Presidential Debate Research

The non-presidential debate literature is rare and is dispersed in ways that makes tracking the research difficult. Recent efforts to summarize this research literature have cited four (McKinney & Carlin, 2004) and six studies (Louden, in press), respectively. This forum adds reviews of seven articles relevant to this limited literature and provides a more exhaustive review of existing studies, expanding the number to thirteen.

Seven studies assessed in some fashion a fundamental question addressed in the presidential debate literature; the comparative “learning” voters obtain from political debates. Lichtenstein (1982) looked at a series of local election debates in Albuquerque, New Mexico, finding they were more informative and influential in voting decisions than the Presidential debates of 1980. This is consistent with the notion that voters decide later in the state election cycle and tend to have less knowledge of the candidates (races seen as less important). He argues that the context surrounding debates has much to do with their effects.

Bystrom, Roper, Gobetz, Massey, and Beall (1991) examined pre- and post-debate shifts on issue and image for two Oklahoma gubernatorial candidates, demonstrating that the debate contributed to significant “learning.” The study subjects were fairly naive about the elections studied and thus were open to greater knowledge acquisition. The implicit argument, shared with Lichtenstein’s findings, indicates that in statewide races there often is more to learn, both about candidates as reliable and unreliable persona and about specific issues defining the race.

Hullett and Loudon (1998) looked at a North Carolina congressional debate assessing voter recall two weeks after viewing the debate live. Respondents not only

outlets, give nearly instant access to debates at all levels. Further availability will emerge with Web sites like scoopdebate.com.

recalled issues (e.g., taxes) and image information (e.g., experience) from the debate, consistent with presidential studies, but also recalled considerable comments that were “performance evaluations” (e.g., relational and presentational judgments).

Philport and Balon (1975) examined, using the then cutting-edge methodology of semantic differential and multivariate analysis, a primary senate debate between Ohio incumbent Howard Metzenbaum and challenger John Glenn. They examined the way in which differing media, specifically television vs. radio, interacted with candidate image. Although the differences found were minimal, the better-known Metzenbaum was found to be competent regardless of exposure, while Glenn’s trustworthiness was enhanced on television. The provoking aspect, not addressed in this study, is that “audio only” encounters elicit more content than image evaluations, shades of the mythical Nixon/Kennedy study of “those who heard the debate” (“Debate Score,” 1960, Druckman, 2003, Vancil & Pendell, 1987).

Pfau (1983) examined three South Dakota races, comparing journalists and participants’ satisfaction with format types and resulting levels of clash. The state-wide debates encouraged interchange between candidates and favorably compared with the Carter-Reagan debate of the same year. In arguing for “better debates” (i.e., more informative debates), Pfau proposed that state-level campaigns have more freedom to stage informative debates, thereby improving voter learning.

Finally, Robertson (2005), measuring pre- and post-debate attitude shifts in the media effects tradition, found that a collegiate population had shifted opinion on selected image qualities after watching a *Meet the Press* debate between South Dakota senate candidates John Thune and Tom Daschle. The debate performance itself shifted evaluation of personal factors (e.g., believable, sincere) and some issue assessment (e.g. war in Iraq), largely favoring the challenger Thune.

Eight additional studies looked at the textual content of debates, examining specific variables. Johnson (1996) looked at “Intertextuality” in the 1994 Texas Gubernatorial (Richards and G. W. Bush) and the U. S. Senate race (Hutchinson and Fisher), exploring

how candidates referenced internal and external information in the debates. Although all candidates tended to support their argument via referents, gubernatorial candidates were more likely to reference their “agenda” and senators “specific legislation,” functions consistent with their respective offices. Johnson’s work suggests that not only content but argumentative form may vary among types of statewide races and perhaps with the presidential level.

Jarvis and Connaughton (2005) examined a unique Texas Gubernatorial set in which two Democratic primary debates were held back-to-back, one in Spanish and one in English. Looking specifically at the nature of journalist questions they found the Spanish debate to ask more about ethnic-specific issues and to be less “substantive” in questions and answers (more character challenges and defense). Undoubtedly the implied audience for state-based debates varies significantly and would influence debate content and argumentative structure.

Airne and Benoit (2005) applied Benoit’s long-standing functional analysis to two senate debates in Illinois between Alan Keyes and Barack Obama. They found the candidates employed acclaims and attacks much like presidential debates. They also noted increased emphasis on policy as compared to presidential candidates, but also with more discussion of personal qualities as introductions to voters. The differences seemed dependent more on the nature of an open-seat debate than presidential vs. non-presidential differences.

Edelsky and Adams’ (1990) work compared gender effects for how candidates were treated in debates. They employed six debates, including governor, U.S. Senate, and representative debates from Arizona, Connecticut, and Missouri, each with one female candidate. They found that males were treated better and exercised more power (e.g., extra turns, more speech time), even though the debates were designed for an equitable playing field.

Banwart and McKinney (2005) bring their work on female and male *debate styles* to a pair of 2000 mixed-sex gubernatorial debates (MT, NH) as well as two U.S. Senate

debates (MO, NC). They found that although generally, men and women candidates engage in “gendered adaptiveness,” adopting both masculine and feminine styles, nonetheless, important differences arose. Interestingly same-gender as well as cross-gender differences were found between senate- and governor-level candidates, perhaps illustrating additional adaptation to the offices sought.

Hill (2005) examined two Democratic (3-F, 7-M) primary gubernatorial debates in Louisiana. She views the debates as “linguistically controlled environments” and not political events per se, examining gendered use of pronouns. Overall men’s usage was more varied, including presumed inclusive uses associated with feminine speech.

Collectively, the thirteen studies reviewed signal increased interest in non-presidential debates as influential communicative events. Importantly, they illustrate that while many of the lessons learned from the presidential debate literature are applicable, state and local debates also include unique content and strategy and undoubtedly a myriad of factors yet to be discovered. Additionally, the gender studies, for example, demonstrate the accessibility of non-presidential examples and allow theory testing beyond Geraldine Ferraro’s single Vice Presidential Debate. Indeed, the assessment of formats and varied media would profit from the varied instances the non-presidential debate laboratories present.

Forum Preview

The current forum introduces three studies that represent disparate traditions, each taking a distinct tact from the reviewed articles. Each is introduced with commentary on the contributions of their line of inquiry.

1. History: Most histories of political debates open with the Kennedy/Nixon debates, implicitly arguing that they were the first mediated debates that mattered. Undeniably, the four debates were seminal in establishing the practice of televised debates, but were

certainly not the first,¹ or the only debates in the 1960 season.¹ Sandra J. Sarkela, University of Memphis, adds to our collective memory of debates, filling in another “forgotten” early broadcast political debate, examining the Maine Senate debate between Lucia Cormier and Margaret Chase Smith. She reconstructs the context and content of the first debate among two female senate candidates and situates its importance in the unfolding increase in political access for women candidates.

2. Practice: According to Jamie McKown, College of Charleston, the opportunity, pitfalls, and logistics of hosting political debates on campus are often overlooked. One of his strongest points is the value of thoroughly planning for debates and methods of persuading campaigners to sign on. I have worked on the planning committee of a number of campus debates, both as a host and negotiator representing a particular campaign. The advice offered in his article rings true, in particular balancing specificity with ambiguity, offering a hook, and offer timing.

One assumption underlying the value of debates from academics has been the utility of debates for students, primarily as a pedagogical tool (Apker & Voss, 1994; Carlin, 2000). McKown develops the tensions that surround the “role” of students in hosting events; in particular, he explores the choices and tradeoffs inherent in planning debates that serve student interests. His argument expands the notion of “meaningful student participation” beyond focusing debates on “their issues” to a more hands-on perspective wisely bridging student interests and hosting a politically relevant production.

Despite the fact that most schools will never have the opportunity to host a Presidential debate, there is much to be learned from schools that have. In the last few cycles, host institutions have developed extensive Web sites, most of which are still active.

¹ The first was in 1948, when Republicans Harold Stassen and Thomas Dewey debated on radio just days before the Oregon primary (Ray, 1961). “In May 1952, the first nationally televised debate, Republican and Democratic contenders (or their representatives) answered two questions each at the annual convention of the League of Women Voters. On May 21, 1956, Democrats Estes Kefauver and Adlai Stevenson participated in the first nationally televised intra-party primary debate (before the Florida primary).” (All*Politics).

Venue planning for presidential debates is extensive and involves diverse segments of campus life; always inclusive of students and academic sectors. The result is a rich list of suggestions for inclusion of students in hosted events. Simply visiting host school Web sites provides dozens of ideas (e.g. Debate 2004, Centre Debate 2000).

Wake Forest University was fortunate to host Presidential debates in 1988 and 2000. The learning curve of hosting a second time resulted in many innovative roles for student involvement. My most effective tool was offering a full academic class dedicated to presidential debates. The students became a credible media resource, hosted seminars/panels, planned and executed community outreach, developed unique Web resources and conducted survey research. The point here, as McKown argues, is to think “outside the box,” even if students are simply providing hospitality or playing the role of a passive audience.

McKown explores the value of “partnering” with community groups and media entities. He rightly warns that commercial media will want to take over, feature station talent, and even function as negotiators for the event. He counsels how the academic host can best retain control of the event while maximizing the advantage of media resources. I would add that media alliance is often crucial, not only for advertising and legitimacy, but more practically they often are the only community-based resource with the technology to stage an event. Making a debate available for C-SPAN and state networks (even radio) require an expertise that is not part of the job description for most argumentation faculty.

One of more salient topics McKown addresses is the host’s role in establishing formats. He advocates a firm flexibility, where the host presents the format, while remaining open to changes. He suggests formats to maximize candidate interaction, with fewer scripted and more authentic moments (e.g., dropping opening and closing statements, fluid turn taking). My experience in framing political debates is that most campaigns and hosts do not have preferred formats in mind. Like all of us, they default to familiar forms. Hosts are

¹ Mary Ann Watson provides an oral history of the Hubert Humphrey and John Kennedy West Virginia televised primary debate in 1960.

surprisingly open to innovations that maximize spontaneous candidate interaction, and campaigns can be convinced to use a particular format to allow their candidate to shine. State and local debates are apt laboratories for experimenting with formats. Standing behind a lectern and trading pre-planned barbs does not serve host, voter, or, arguably, even campaigns.

3. Criticism: C. Thomas Preston of Gainesville State College taps into a long tradition for the study of political debates where they are probed for their argumentative qualities. He examines one of the more influential non-presidential debates of 2000, Hillary Clinton vs. Rick Lazio, from the perspective of how their ability to associate or disassociate (as informed by the work of Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca) with being a “New Yorker” as well as their favorable or unfavorable backgrounds. The way arguments operated to situate their opponent through their own self acclaims also informs the work. The Clinton-Lazio debate is certain to be revisited as the 2008 presidential race heats up.

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